

THE CIRCLE

MVP Architecture Document

Artist Platform Phase 1

Version	1.0
Date	May 2026
Audience	Developer, Product Owner
Scope	Phase 1 MVP: Artist profile, package builder, booking and escrow

| ***Build the tool artists cannot live without. Everything else follows.***

1. Purpose and Scope

This document defines the technical and product architecture for The Circle's Phase 1 MVP. Its purpose is to align the developer and product owner on what we are building, how the system is structured, and why each decision was made.

The MVP has one primary goal:

| ***Get 50 artists using the platform every week without being pushed.***

To achieve this, we solve three artist pain points and nothing else in Phase 1.

Problem	Solution	MVP?
Artists not getting paid	Escrow + auto-contract on every booking	Yes - Tentative
Scattered, unprofessional portfolio	One holistic profile one shareable link	Yes
Cannot productise their art	Package builder with rate card export	Yes
Cannot find opportunities	Gig discovery feed and opp alerts	Yes: partly
No professional knowledge access	GoodWorks library and legal templates	Yes: partly

2. User Types

1. Artist:
2. Audience

2.1 Artist

Who they are	Poets, dancers, musicians, spoken word artists, performers
Primary jobs	Build a professional profile, create packages, get booked safely, get paid reliably, discover opportunities, get professional knowledge
Onboarding	Manual but automated. The founding team knows each of the first 50 artists personally. Artists can sign up on the platform without any assistance.
Device	Mobile-first. Most artists will access via phone browser. WhatsApp is their primary communication channel.

2.2 Audience

Who they are	Individuals, friend groups, small businesses, or event organisers looking to book an artist
Primary jobs	Discover an artist, view their portfolio and packages, book and pay safely
Onboarding	Organic: they receive a shareable link from an artist and land on the artist's public profile
Device	Mixed. Some mobile, some desktop. The booking flow must work on both.

3. MVP Feature Blocks

The MVP is organised into three feature blocks. Each block maps to one artist problem.

3.1 Block 1: Profile and Portfolio

The artist's professional identity on The Circle. One link that replaces the need for an individual website:

- About and Bio
- Portfolio: IG, Youtube, Tiktok, LinkedIn
- Products and Packages
- Upcoming Events
- Contact details

Core features

- Bio and profile photo
- Art form and discipline tags
- Media uploads: video, audio, written work, images
- Social media links aggregated in one place
- Products and Packages integrated
- Shareable public link (thecircle.co/artist-name)
- Export: profile exportable as a PDF or shareable image for WhatsApp and Instagram
- Push profile to social media platforms directly

3.2 Block 2: Package Builder

Helps artists turn their art into named, priced products. Removes the guesswork on pricing and gives audiences a clear, professional menu of what they can buy.

Core features

- Product creation: name, description, duration, price, logistics toggle (transport and accommodation inclusive or exclusive)
- Template library: Poet Template, Musician Template, Dancer Template; artists fill in their price, not a blank form
- Availability calendar: artist marks blackout dates, booked dates auto-block
- Rate card PDF export: a formatted menu of services with a QR code linking to their Circle profile
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Anatomy of a product

Name	E.g. The Corporate Opening Set
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Description	What is included: duration, customisation, deliverables
Duration	15 mins, 1 hour, Full Day
Price	Fixed amount in local currency
Logistics	Toggle: inclusive or exclusive of transport and accommodation

3.3 Block 3: Booking and Payment

The trust and payment infrastructure. Every booking on The Circle goes through escrow. A contract is auto-generated before any money moves.

Core features

- Booking request: audience selects package, date, time, adds notes
- Artist accept or decline (24-hour window)
- Auto-generated contract: pre-filled with gig details, signed digitally by both parties
- Escrow payment: audience pays via mobile money or card, funds held by The Circle
- Gig day check-in: artist marks arrived, audience gets notification
- Double confirmation: both parties confirm gig complete, funds release(escrow coming soon)
- Commission split: 85 to 90 percent to artist, 10 to 15 percent to The Circle
- Edge cases: no-show triggers full refund, advance cancellation follows contract terms, disputes mediated by The Circle using the signed contract.

4. Booking State Machine

A booking moves through the following states. State transitions must be enforced server-side, the audience cannot manually set a booking to any state. Every transition triggers notifications to both parties.

State	Triggered By	Actor	Notes
REQUESTED	Audience submits booking	Audience	Artist receives email and push notification. 24-hour window to accept or decline.
ACCEPTED	Artist taps Accept	Artist	Contract auto-generates. Both parties receive it for signing.
DECLINED	Artist taps Decline	Artist	Audience notified. No money has moved. Booking closed.
CONTRACT_SIGNED	Both parties sign	Both	Payment step unlocks. Neither can skip this.
PAYMENT_HELD	Audience completes payment	Audience	Funds sit in escrow. Artist sees confirmation but cannot access funds.
GIG_ACTIVE	Gig date is reached	System	Reminders sent the day before and 2 hours before to both parties. Artist receives professional etiquette reminder.
CHECKED_IN	Artist marks arrived	Artist	Optional but recommended. Audience notified.
CONFIRMING	Gig date has passed	System	Both parties prompted to confirm session complete.
COMPLETED	Both parties confirm	Both	Funds released. Commission deducted. Review prompts sent.
AUTO_RELEASED	48hr grace period expires	System	If one party confirms and the other goes silent, funds auto-release.
DISPUTED	One party raises dispute	Either	Funds frozen. The Circle reviews signed contract. Decision within 72hrs.
REFUNDED	No-show confirmed or cancelled	The Circle	Full or partial refund per contract terms. No-show flag added to artist profile.
CANCELLED	Artist/ Audience cancels in advance	Artist	Penalty applied per contract terms. 48hr window means partial penalty. 7+ days means full refund.

5. System Architecture

The system is structured in four layers: frontend, backend API, third-party integrations, and data. The backend is a set of loosely coupled services, each owning one domain. They communicate synchronously via REST for now. Event-driven messaging can be introduced in Phase 2 as load grows.

5.1 Frontend

Type	Mobile-first responsive web app.
Framework	Next Js
Rationale	Artists can be sent a WhatsApp link that opens immediately. No app store. Faster to ship and iterate. There is an automatic preview on the link
Key screens	Auth and onboarding, artist dashboard, public profile, package manager, booking flow, payment confirmation, earnings summary

5.2 Backend Services

Each service owns its domain. At MVP scale, these can live in a single Node.js or Python monorepo and be split into separate services later if needed.

Framework: Next Js + Supabase

Service	Owns	Key responsibilities	Tools / technologies required
User service	Profiles, auth, sessions	Sign up, log in, artist and audience profile CRUD, session management	Google OAuth: Supabase
Portfolio service	Media, EPK, exports	File upload, media management, EPK PDF generation, shareable link	
Package service	Products, pricing, calendar	Package CRUD, template library, rate card PDF, availability calendar	
Booking service	Booking state machine, contracts	State transitions, contract generation, notifications, dispute logic	Email service
Payment service	Escrow, releases, refunds, splits	Hold funds, release on confirmation, refund on no-show, commission deduction	Payment gateway
Notification service	WhatsApp, SMS, email	Trigger messages on all state transitions, reminders, confirmations	Email service, whatsapp twillio,

5.3 Third-Party Integrations

Category	Tool	Why
Payments	Flutterwave	Handles MTN Mobile Money, Airtel Money, and card across East Africa. Has escrow-like transfer and split APIs. Already licensed.
File and media	Cloudinary	Video, audio, and image upload and transformation. Free tier covers MVP scale.
Document generation	Puppeteer or PDF-lib	Render HTML contract and EPK templates to PDF server-side.
Notifications	Twilio WhatsApp API	Primary notification channel. Artists live on WhatsApp. Beats push notifications at this scale.
Email	Resend or Postmark	Transactional email fallback for booking confirmations and receipts.
Auth	Supabase Auth or Auth0	Handles sign-up, log-in, and session management without building from scratch.
Database hosting	Supabase	Managed PostgreSQL. Cheap at MVP scale, easy to migrate off if needed.

5.4 Data Layer

PostgreSQL is the primary database. All relational data: users, profiles, packages, bookings, transactions: lives here. Media files live in Cloudinary. Generated PDFs are stored in object storage (Cloudinary or S3-compatible).

Core data models

Model	Key fields	Notes
Artist	id, name, bio, artForm, socialLinks, portfolioLink, primaryLocation	One-to-many with Package and Booking
Audience	id, name, email, phone, innerCircle[]	innerCircle is a list of Artist ids they have worked with
Package	id, artistId, name, description, duration, price, tier	Belongs to Artist. One Artist has many Packages.
Availability	id, artistId, bookedDates[]	Linked to Package. Auto-updated on booking state changes.
Booking	id, artistId, audienceId, packageId, state, date, notes	The central model. State field drives the entire flow.
Contract	id, bookingId, terms, signedByArtist, signedByAudience	Generated on ACCEPTED state. Required before PAYMENT_HELD.
Transaction	id, bookingId, amount, currency, status, paymentRef	One per booking. Tracks escrow hold, release, and refund.
Review	id, bookingId, authorId, rating, vouches[], comment	Created after COMPLETED state. Vouches are skill tags.

MediaItem	id, artistId, type, url, title	Portfolio items. Type: video, audio, image, text.
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6. API Structure

The API follows REST conventions. All endpoints are prefixed with /api/v1. Authentication uses JWT tokens. All booking state transitions are explicit endpoints, the state cannot be set directly via a PATCH on the booking model.

Auth

Method	Endpoint	Description
POST	/auth/signup	Create artist or audience account
POST	/auth/login	Log in, receive JWT
POST	/auth/refresh	Refresh access token

Artist and portfolio

Method	Endpoint	Description
GET	/artists/:id	Get public artist profile
PATCH	/artists/:id	Update profile (auth required)
POST	/artists/:id/media	Upload media item
DELETE	/artists/:id/media/:mediaId	Remove media item
GET	/artists/:id/epk	Generate and return EPK as PDF
GET	/artists/:id/profile.pdf	Export profile as PDF

Packages

Method	Endpoint	Description
GET	/artists/:id/packages	List all packages for an artist
POST	/artists/:id/packages	Create a new package
PATCH	/packages/:id	Update a package
DELETE	/packages/:id	Remove a package
GET	/packages/:id/ratecard.pdf	Export rate card as PDF
GET	/artists/:id/availability	Get availability calendar
POST	/artists/:id/availability/blackout	Add blackout dates

Bookings (state transitions are explicit)

Method	Endpoint	Description
POST	/bookings	Audience creates booking request (state: REQUESTED)

POST	/bookings/:id/accept	Artist accepts (state: ACCEPTED, contract generated)
POST	/bookings/:id/decline	Artist declines (state: DECLINED)
POST	/bookings/:id/sign	Artist or audience signs contract
POST	/bookings/:id/pay	Audience pays into escrow (state: PAYMENT_HELD)
POST	/bookings/:id/checkin	Artist marks arrived (state: CHECKED_IN)
POST	/bookings/:id/confirm	Artist or audience confirms gig complete
POST	/bookings/:id/dispute	Either party raises a dispute (state: DISPUTED)
GET	/bookings/:id	Get booking details
GET	/bookings	List bookings for current user

Payments

Method	Endpoint	Description
GET	/transactions/:bookingId	Get transaction status for a booking
POST	/webhooks/flutterwave	Flutterwave payment webhook (internal)
GET	/artists/:id/earnings	Artist earnings summary

7. Notification Logic

Notifications are triggered by booking state transitions. WhatsApp is the primary channel. SMS is the fallback. Email is for receipts and documents. Push notifications are Phase 2.

State transition	Artist notified	Audience notified
REQUESTED	New booking request from [Audience]	Booking request sent to [Artist]
ACCEPTED	You accepted. Contract ready to sign.	Artist accepted. Contract ready to sign.
DECLINED	You declined the booking.	Artist is unavailable for that date.
CONTRACT_SIGNED	Contract fully signed. Payment is now unlocked.	Contract fully signed. Please proceed to payment.
PAYMENT_HELD	Payment of [amount] is held in escrow for your gig on [date].	Payment confirmed. Your booking is secured.
GIG_ACTIVE	Reminder: your gig with [Audience] is tomorrow.	Reminder: [Artist] performs tomorrow.
COMPLETED	Payment of [amount] has been released to you.	Session confirmed complete. Please leave a review.
REFUNDED	Booking cancelled. Cancellation terms applied.	You have been refunded [amount].
DISPUTED	A dispute has been raised. The Circle will review within 72 hours.	A dispute has been raised. The Circle will review within 72 hours.

8. Non-Functional Requirements

8.1 Performance

- Public artist profiles must load in under 2 seconds on a 3G connection
- Booking state transitions must complete in under 1 second
- PDF generation (EPK, rate card, contract) must complete in under 5 seconds

8.2 Security

- All API endpoints require JWT authentication except public artist profiles
- Booking state transitions are server-enforced — no audience-side state manipulation
- Payment amounts are set server-side from the package record — audiences cannot pass an amount
- Signed contracts are stored in object storage and cannot be modified after signing
- Escrow funds are never touched by application code directly — all payment operations go through Flutterwave's API

8.3 Reliability

- Payment webhooks from Flutterwave must be idempotent — duplicate events must not trigger duplicate releases
- Booking state machine must be transactional — a state change and its side effects (notification, payment release) must succeed or fail together
- The 48-hour auto-release must be handled by a scheduled job, not a audience trigger

8.4 Scalability

- MVP target: 50 artists, 200 bookings per month. No horizontal scaling needed at this stage.
- Architecture should support splitting services if a single service becomes a bottleneck, but premature optimisation is explicitly out of scope.

8.5 Mobile and Accessibility

- All screens must be fully usable on a 375px wide phone browser
- WhatsApp notification links must deep-link directly to the relevant booking or action
- Payment flow must support MTN Mobile Money and Airtel Money as primary methods

9. Open Questions for Product and Developer

These are decisions that need to be made before or during the first sprint. They are flagged here so they are not accidentally resolved by default.

Question	Options	Recommended default
What currency do we hold escrow in?	UGX only vs multi-currency from day one	UGX only for MVP. Add KES, TZS in Phase 2.
Who is the licensed payment entity?	Use Flutterwave as the escrow holder vs set up our own trust account	Flutterwave for MVP. Revisit when transaction volume justifies a local trust account.
How do we handle tax on artist payments?	Deduct withholding tax automatically vs leave to artist	Leave to artist for MVP. Add a tax guide to GoodWorks in Phase 2.
Do audiences need an account to book?	Guest checkout vs mandatory sign-up	Guest checkout with phone number. Reduces friction for first-time audiences.
How strict is the 24-hour accept window?	Hard cutoff vs soft reminder	Hard cutoff with a reminder at 12 hours. Keeps the booking flow predictable.
Who resolves disputes and what is the SLA?	Founding team manually vs a defined process	Founding team manually for MVP with a 72-hour SLA. Document the process now.
Do we build the EPK generator with AI or static templates?	Static template fill vs Claude API generation	Static templates for MVP. AI-assisted generation is a compelling Phase 2 feature.

10. Recommended Build Order

Build in this sequence. Each step is a shippable unit that can be tested with real artists before the next step is started.

Sprint	What to build	Why this order
Sprint 1	Database schema, booking state machine, core API skeleton	Everything depends on the state machine. Build it first, build it right.
Sprint 2	Auth, artist profile, media upload, shareable public link	Artists need a profile before they can create packages or receive bookings.
Sprint 3	Package builder, availability calendar, rate card PDF	Packages are required for the booking flow. Get one artist's packages live.
Sprint 4	Booking flow: request, accept, contract generation, sign	The trust mechanic. End-to-end without payment first so the flow can be tested.
Sprint 5	Payment integration: Flutterwave escrow, hold, release, refund	Add payment last so the state machine is proven before money touches it.
Sprint 6	WhatsApp notifications for all state transitions	Notifications are what make the product feel alive. Add them before launch.
Sprint 7	EPK generator, profile PDF export, rate card polish	Portfolio exports. Nice to have before launch but not blocking the core flow.
Launch	Onboard first 10 artists manually. Run 3 real bookings end to end.	Do not onboard 50 artists before you have run 3 real bookings with money.